Objection-Handling Guide

Document	MCPG-04, version 1.0.0
Effective date	2026-10-20
Access	Field representatives and regional managers
Status	draft for team review
Source	Team 1 authored fictional Marvel CPG document (fictional company documents are permitted by the capstone brief and the official client clarifications); evidence from the project dataset, the Team 1 V3 EDA and the public references PUB-01 to PUB-03

Marvel CPG is a fictional company created for the University at Buffalo CDA 650 capstone. This document was written by Team 1 for the project's RAG knowledge base. Figures marked data *come from the project dataset; everything else is fictional business content.*

1 How to handle an objection

Use the same four steps every time:

1. **Listen and acknowledge.** Repeat the concern in the buyer's words.
2. **Find what is behind it**: space, price, risk or a past bad experience.
3. **Answer with one fact the buyer can check**: a figure from this guide, the product sheet or the dashboard.
4. **Propose a small next step** that the store can accept today, and agree when to review it.

Each objection below lists what is usually behind it, a suggested response, the evidence to show, and what not to do. Figures marked *(data)* come from the project dataset, Authorized V3 dataset (dataset hash f5403651d8aa...), reported sell-out rows 1 Jan 2025 - 31 May 2026; June 2026 held out.

2 Common objections

2.1 "I don't want to take the new degreaser line."

What is usually behind it. The buyer sees another SKU competing for limited shelf space, is unsure it will sell, or already stocks a competitor degreaser.

Response. Acknowledge the space concern, then show that the degreaser is not an experiment. The Heavy-Duty Degreaser 1 L is already the best-selling Surface Cleaner by value. Propose the smallest commitment that proves it: one facing of the 1 L (it is a Must-Stock SKU) and, if space allows, the 500 ml as a lower-priced trial pack. Agree to review sales together at the next visit, and time the start to the spring peak.

Evidence to show. *(data)* Degreaser 1 L: #1 Surface Cleaner by consumer sales value (18.9% of the category) and #4 of 23 SKUs overall. It is the highest-priced Surface Cleaner ($5.80 list, $8.07 reference shelf price), so each unit sold is worth more to the store. The 500 ml sells as many units per in-stock day as the 1 L in every tier, but only 128 of 221 accounts carry it. See MCPG-03 section 5.

Do not. Do not promise a sales increase from a display or extra space, and do not attack a competitor product you have no data on.

2.2 "I don't have shelf space."

What is usually behind it. Space is genuinely limited, especially in small-format stores, or the buyer wants something in return for space.

Response. Start with the Must-Stock List: MSL SKUs come first because a store fails MSL compliance for the day if even one is missing. Then look at value per facing. Suggest replacing a slow optional SKU with a faster one rather than adding facings, and follow the planogram.

Evidence to show. *(data)* MSL SKUs are 78% of Marvel's consumer sales value. Small accounts already carry a reduced range: Tier 3 accounts stock a median of 18 of the 23 SKUs, against 22 in Tier 1. Product ranks by value are in each product sheet (MCPG-01).

Do not. Do not ask a Tier 3 store to take the full range. Do not remove an MSL SKU to make room.

2.3 "Your products are too expensive / my margin is too low."

What is usually behind it. The buyer compares the trade price with a competitor's, or wants a larger discount.

Response. Separate the two prices. The trade list price is what the store pays Marvel; the reference consumer price is what shoppers pay. Show the store's margin between the two, then the value of keeping the product available. If a discount is still needed, use the guardrail process: discounts within the account's cap can be agreed, and larger ones need an execution commitment and manager review (MCPG-05).

Evidence to show. At the reference consumer price, a retailer buying at list price keeps 23% to 28% of the shelf price before any trade discount (MCPG-01, section 5). Discount caps by channel and category are in MCPG-05, section 4.

Do not. Do not offer a discount above the cap as if it were approved, and do not quote a competitor's price.

2.4 "Your competitor gives me a bigger discount."

What is usually behind it. A negotiation opening; the buyer is testing the rep's limits.

Response. Do not match on price alone. Ask what the competitor discount is tied to, then offer what Marvel can give within policy: a discount up to the account's cap, a promotion slot from the calendar (MCPG-07), or a larger discount in exchange for the execution commitment named in the guardrail (for example +10 percentage points of shelf share or a secondary display), subject to manager review.

Evidence to show. Guardrail caps and required trade-offs by channel and category: MCPG-05, section 4. Promotion lift by type: MCPG-07, section 4.

Do not. Do not exceed the cap without the required commitment and review. Do not combine a trade discount and a consumer promotion as if they were one discount.

2.5 "I'm overstocked / your products don't sell here."

What is usually behind it. Stock is sitting in the back room, or the shelf sells slowly in this store.

Response. Check the store's own figures in the dashboard before answering: units sold per day, stock on hand and recent invoices. If stock really is high, do not push more volume. Agree a smaller, more frequent order and use a promotion or display to move the stock. If the shelf is often empty instead, the store is under-stocked, not over-stocked.

Evidence to show. *(data)* Small accounts run out of stock most: 15.1% of store-days in Tier 3, against 2.9% in Tier 1. Promotion days sell 12.9% more units on average (MCPG-07).

Do not. Do not load the store with more stock than it sells. Shipping ahead of demand shows up later as a sell-in versus sell-out gap (MCPG-08).

2.6 "Your deliveries are always late."

What is usually behind it. The store had a recent late delivery or ran out of stock waiting for one.

Response. Acknowledge it with the facts. Late deliveries happen, but they explain only a small part of stock-outs; most empty shelves come from ordering too late. Offer to agree a reorder point with the store and to raise the store's delivery issues with logistics.

Evidence to show. *(data)* Late deliveries: 24% in Traditional Trade, 12% in Modern Trade and 6.5% for Distributors. Fill rate is about 99% in every channel. Only about 10% of stock-out days fall inside a late-delivery window (Team 1 V3 EDA, section 8.6). Median order-to-arrival time: 2 days for Distributors, 3 for Modern Trade, 5 for Traditional Trade.

Do not. Do not blame the store or promise a delivery date that logistics has not confirmed.

2.7 "Out-of-stocks don't matter, shoppers just buy something else."

What is usually behind it. The buyer believes demand moves to another product on the same shelf.

Response. Explain that many shoppers do not substitute. They go to another store, wait, or do not buy at all, so the sale is lost for both the store and Marvel. Offer the substitution guide for emergencies, but focus on preventing the

gap.

Evidence to show. In a field study of real stock-outs, 41.5% of shoppers went to another store, 22% postponed, 18.1% switched to another size or type, 12.2% did not buy and 6.3% switched brand (PUB-01). *(data)* In Marvel's data, the first-choice substitute sells only about 2% to 4% more on days the original is out of stock (MCPG-02). Estimated lost sales: 4.8% of potential overall, 13.8% in Tier 3 accounts.

Do not. Do not overstate the research: it is one field study in German and Swiss supermarkets across many categories, not Marvel's own shoppers.

2.8 "Why should I order more often? I'm a small store."

What is usually behind it. Small stores have little storage, limited cash and infrequent visits.

Response. Agree a simple reorder point: order when the shelf still holds about a week of normal sales, not when it is empty, because delivery takes several days. Smaller, more frequent orders keep the shelf full without tying up cash.

Evidence to show. *(data)* Tier 3 accounts place orders when the shelf holds a median of about 4 days of sales, and 31% of their orders are placed when the shelf is already empty. As a result, 48% of Tier 3 restocks arrive after the shelf has run out, against 8% in Tier 1. Tier 3 accounts restock a SKU about every 28 days, against 12 in Tier 1 (Team 1 V3 EDA, section 8.2).

Do not. Do not ask a small store to hold the stock levels of a Tier 1 account.

2.9 "Following the planogram is too much work."

What is usually behind it. Staff time is short, or the buyer does not see the benefit.

Response. Keep it practical: the planogram puts MSL SKUs where shoppers look for them and makes gaps easy to spot at a glance, which helps the store reorder in time. Offer to help reset the shelf during the visit.

Evidence to show. Industry evidence: a retail merchandising association study cited by Frontoni et al. (2015) linked full planogram compliance to a 7.8% sales lift and an 8.1% profit improvement (PUB-02). *(data)* Planogram compliance is 95% in Modern Trade Tier 1 accounts and 53% in Traditional Trade Tier 3 accounts.

Do not. Do not promise the 7.8% figure for this store. It is an industry study, and Marvel's own data shows no measurable sales difference from planogram compliance alone.

2.10 "What do I get for giving you a secondary display?"

What is usually behind it. The buyer wants something back for the space.

Response. A secondary display (endcap, island or checkout display) is one of the execution commitments that can support a larger discount under the guardrails, subject to manager review (MCPG-05). It also gives seasonal and promoted products extra visibility.

Evidence to show. Required trade-offs by channel and category are listed in MCPG-05, section 4. *(data)* Secondary displays are present at 49% of audited SKU visits overall: about 59% to 69% in Tier 1 accounts and 17% to 26% in Tier 3.

Do not. Do not promise a fixed sales increase from a display; the data does not show one.

2.11 "Promotions only cut my margin."

What is usually behind it. The buyer has seen promotions that moved volume but not profit.

Response. Show the measured effect: units go up by roughly the same percentage as the price goes down, so revenue holds while the store gains traffic and visibility. Choose the promotion type that fits the store, and stock up before it starts, because stock-outs rise on promotion days.

Evidence to show. *(data)* Average lift 12.9% at about 11% off; BOGO +23%, Volume +20%, TPR +15%, Feature +13%, Display +11%, Bundle +2% (MCPG-07). Stock-outs on promotion days vs other days: Modern Trade 8.3% vs 6.3%, Traditional Trade 10.4% vs 8.6%, Distributors 10.1% vs 7.7%.

Do not. Do not run a promotion without checking that the order will arrive before it starts.

2.12 "(Distributor) I want the volume deal now, outside the deal period."

What is usually behind it. The distributor wants volume pricing all year.

Response. Volume deals are planned for set windows (Q1 and Q3). Outside them, the distributor's trade discount must stay within its guardrail cap, or go through manager review with the required commitment. Offer to plan the next order into the next volume window.

Evidence to show. Distributor Volume Deals: 14% off, minimum 200 units (MCPG-07). Distributor discount caps are 15.07% to 17.80% depending on category (MCPG-05).

Do not. Do not ask a distributor for shelf-execution commitments: distributors are wholesale accounts and negotiate volume, not shelf space.

2.13 "Is it safe to use the degreaser or bleach with other cleaners?"

What is usually behind it. A shopper or store owner asks a safety question.

Response. No. Never mix cleaning products. Point to the product label and the safe-use guidance: read and follow the label, ventilate, wear gloves where the label says so, and keep products away from children and pets.

Evidence to show. Public health guidance (CDC, PUB-03): mixing bleach with vinegar or ammonia can release chlorine or chloramine gases that can severely damage the lungs. Product cautions are in each product sheet (MCPG-01).

Do not. Do not give medical advice. For an exposure, direct the person to the label and to a poison control centre or medical help.

3 When to escalate

- The account asks for a discount above its cap and offers no execution commitment: the proposal is a policy breach (MCPG-05). Explain the limit and offer alternatives.
- The account offers the commitment but the discount is above the cap: prepare the proposal for manager review. Do not confirm it yourself.
- The account raises a safety incident or a product complaint: record it and pass it to the regional manager the same day.

Document control

Item	Value
Document	MCPG-04, version 1.0.0
Effective date	2026-10-20
Owner	Team 1 knowledge base (Sanika Najan)
Status	Draft for team review
Source	Project dataset: Authorized V3 dataset (dataset hash f5403651d8aa...), reported sell-out rows 1 Jan 2025 - 31 May 2026; June 2026 held out
Source	Team 1 V3 EDA (notebook 01_v3_eda): sections 8.1, 8.2, 8.5, 8.6, 8.7
Source	Public references PUB-01 (out-of-stock shopper responses), PUB-02 (planogram compliance), PUB-03 (safe use of cleaning products)

Open points and review notes

- Responses are suggested wording for training and the copilot, not a script that must be read verbatim.
- Discount limits follow the retained guardrail table in MCPG-05; any change to that table must be reflected here.